

modern India that doesn't believe in blindly falling into the roles society places them in, where the man goes to office and the wife looks after the home. Money and economics are fluid. Anik makes more money now, but he says there were times when he had to completely rely on his wife's money for them to sail through.

Call them house-husbands, primary caregivers or SAHD (stay-at-home dads), they are part of a rising phenomenon. Anik, an independent filmmaker, gave up his job 15 years ago because he

"I ALWAYS ASKED MY FATHER THE BIGGER QUESTIONS AS I SPENT MORE TIME WITH HIM. I WANT TO BE LIKE HIM WHEN I GROW UP BECAUSE I WOULD HAVE MORE TIME AT HAND."

OISHEE DUTTA

found a nine-to-five schedule stifling. His wife, Sondhy, on the other hand, is the model employee as retail manager of Hutch. "My compulsion to work stems from a deep sense of insecurity. I always wonder what would happen if we don't have enough money or I don't know what to do with my spare time," she says.

But then, society is still not very comfortable with a stay-at-home father. Filmmaker Bijon Ray, a father who gave up his work four years ago when his son Sufi was born, says the domestic help snidely calls him Sufi'r Ma (Sufi's mother). But he says that doesn't rile him. His wife, Paroma is an IT professional and it would be difficult for her to bounce back if she quit. "I'm glad my child had a parent around when he was growing up or else it would have been very difficult," he says, epitomising that modern, concerned parent. Clearly, Ray is happy to be SAHD.

After 26 years, a topline executive chucks private profit for public service, giving up ambitious individualism for spirited philanthropy

SOCIAL SERVICE



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Earth mother



■ By Stephen David

Big sister. That's how she felt every time her hands caressed and comforted the wiry limbs or hands of the aged inmates at the Little Sisters of the Poor, a stone's throw from her alma mater, the 125-year-old Jesuit-run St. Joseph's College. "I think the seed of doing something for the senior citizens was sown then itself, some 30 years ago," says Sarasa Vasudevan, 48, who quit a well-paying job, as regional chief of Thai Airways last year, to turn her dream project of a senior citizen home—Vishranti—into a reality.

The seed grows in you and you grow with it, points out the always-saree-clad M.S. Subbulakshmi clone, chipping away at a plate of chilli *bhaji* and south Indian filter coffee at the Bowring Institute. Her husband S. Vasudevan, 49, an IT consultant, she says, has always supported her decision. "I am independent in my own way so it was okay handling him," she says. Her colleagues mocked her decision to take off from work. Some of them suggested she

LEADING BY EXAMPLE: Vasudevan (centre) with Aparijita, mother-in-law Jayalakshmi (left) and mother Padma

go on a long leave and reconsider her decision. "But when you want to pursue your heart's desire, then there is no looking back, even if the big money is missing for a while," she says.

Now she's busy raising money and resources for her dream project—a 22,000-sq ft home for the aged near Jagedanahalli, 35 km north of Bangalore. Her mother Padma Srinivasan, 68, and mother-in-law Jayalakshmi Sreenivasan, 75—the famous pie-making grandmas in the Indian Silicon Valley—are ploughing their pizza profits into the project. Vasudevan and her two highly motivated pizzaiolos are ensuring Vishranti will be reality in two years.

But why this project? "In many parts of the region, the concepts of retirement and pension barely exist, especially in India and we want to do something to help," she says. Though she still gets job offers from the industry she left behind, Vasudevan isn't tempted to return. She'd rather follow her heart.